

HIGH SCHOOLS

Taking on Columbus

Magnificat, Chagrin Falls ready for state

By DICK ZUNT

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Magnificat and Chagrin Falls ride into Columbus this weekend with their shooting eyes set on state girls basketball championships.

GIRLS BASKETBALL Both area teams have 9 p.m. tipoff times; Chagrin Falls plays tonight against Castown Miami East in a Division III semifinal game, and Magnificat plays tomorrow against Mason in a Division I semifinal.

Chagrin Falls, making its fourth trip to the state finals and tied since 1983, is 25-1. Miami East, located in southwestern Ohio's Castown, is 23-2. The championship game is 2 p.m. Saturday.

Magnificat, also making its fourth trip to the Final Four, is the only school in the 16-team field that returns from last year. Magnificat is 23-2 and Mason, located near Cincinnati, is 24-1. The championship game is at 8:30 p.m. Saturday.

"We look at an up-tempo game being a key for us," said Chagrin Falls coach Frank Phillips. "A slow game would be more to their style. Our ability to stop their perimeter game is very important."

"Division III is a tough draw," Phillips said. "If you look at the overall record of the four teams, it's 99-3. The No. 2-3-4 teams in the state are there, but I would rather be there than any other place."

The other two Division III teams are Utica (26-0) and Wauseon (25-0). Unranked Miami East nipped No. 1-ranked Wyoming, 44-43, in the regional final. Utica is ranked No. 2, Wauseon No. 3 and Chagrin Falls No. 4 by the Associated Press.

Last season, Magnificat got to Columbus using the slogan, "win the next one." This year it's different. "Win the last one," said Magnificat coach Larry Chernauskas, whose Blue Streaks lost in the state semifinals last year. "If we win the last one, we're state champions."

Magnificat is ranked No. 9 and Mason is unranked. The other semifinal matches No. 6 Wadsworth (24-1) against No. 1 Pickerington (26-0).

Tonight, when Chagrin Falls enters St. John Arena, Phillips will have experienced athletes with a nice blend of size and quickness.

The starters are 6-0 senior post Kelly Haase, 5-9 junior guard Trish Kruse, 5-10 junior forward Katie Carson, 5-5 sophomore guard Katie Kruse (Trish's sister) and 5-7 junior forward Ashley Wochholz.

"In the first half of the season, we rotated a lot of people," Phillips said. "In the second half, we pretty much went with starters."

"Kelly Haase, a four-year starter, went over 1,000-points for her career. She's our leading scorer with an average of 15.7

points and second-leading rebounder.

"There have been three 1,000-point scorers in school history, Jane Phend and Sue Wise being the others, and all three got to the state tournament," Phillips said. "Trish Cruise [13.5 scoring average] has been our point guard for three years and is our leader in assists and steals and is the second leading scorer," Phillips said. "She's responsible for handling a lot of our full-court offense."

"Katie Carson had a great tourney run," he said. "She averaged 16 points and 14 rebounds in the tournaments and is our leading rebounder and third-leading scorer."

"Katie Kruse handles the ball in the open floor very well, and Ashley Wochholz brings energy and excitement to the floor and is a very good rebounder for her size," Phillips said.

"We're really excited to be in Columbus," Phillips said.

Magnificat brings experience from last year's Final Four, when it lost to Wooster, 58-52, in the semifinals.

What does Magnificat coach Larry Chernauskas see in Mason? "I saw Mason play, and it is a team very much like us," he said. "Like two peas in a pod."

Magnificat's starters are 6-0 Sara Kitchen, 6-0 Denise Happensack, 5-9 Brianne Kennelly, 5-8 Karen Hansen and 5-5 Liz Gibson. All are seniors.

"Karen Hansen has been a starting guard all three years,"



JEFF GLIDDEN / ASSOCIATED PRESS PHOTOGRAPHER

Chagrin Falls player Katie Carson, right, hugs teammate Bit Cornell, and Ashley Wochholz, left, hugs Trish Kruse after Chagrin Falls defeated Mineral Ridge in the regional finals on Saturday. At center is Hilary Gilway.

Chernauskas said. "With her in the lineup, we have won 66 games in three seasons. She, Liz Gibson and Sara Kitchen have played prominent roles."

Denise Happensack has improved immensely, averaging 10 points," he said. "She has been an important factor."

"Brianne Kennelly transferred here two years ago from

Padua and has added that something extra to our team," Chernauskas said. "She is 13 points shy of 1,600 points as a varsity player. She is averaging 17.2 points."

"Liz Gibson is one of the best defensive guards in the area," he said. "She usually is asked to latch onto the opponents' best player."

"Sara Kitchen [who averages 11 points game] is a reliable rebounder and is shooting well over 50 percent for her career."

"It's difficult to maintain your very best when you are always expected to do your best," he said. "This bunch has responded when it's been challenged. We don't run away with games, we're more of a finesse team."

BASKETBALL INSIDER

Cuyahoga boys teams ready for regionals

Olmsted Falls and Benedictine will represent Cuyahoga County tonight in the Division II boys regional basketball tournament at the University of Toledo.

Benedictine (19-5), ranked seventh in the final Associated Press Division II state poll, faces unranked Elida (18-6) at 6:30 and Olmsted Falls (22-1), ranked fourth in the AP poll, takes on 16th-ranked Bellevue (22-2) at 8:15.

Tonight's winners return to Toledo on Saturday for the 3 p.m. championship game.

Under the tutelage of veteran coach Frank Novak, Benedictine is making its first regional appearance since 1991. The Bengals are led by senior guard Rashon Brown, who averaged 20.5 points a game during the regular season. A first-team All-Northeast Lakes District selection, Brown scored a game-high 23 points in Saturday night's 72-58 victory over University School in the district finals.

Olmsted Falls, champion of the Southwestern Conference, is making its third consecutive regional appearance. The Bulldogs have advanced to regional play five times in coach Pat Donahue's eight seasons.

As was the case all through the regular season, Olmsted Falls will rely on its 1-2 punch of 6-8, 240-pound senior center Tim Schaefer and 6-3 senior point guard John Storey.

Schaefer, the player of the year in the SWC and the Division II co-player of the year in the Northeast Lakes District, averages more than 22 points and 10 rebounds a game. He is shooting 73 percent from the field and 70 percent from the free-throw line.

Storey, who earned first-team All-SWC and All-Northeast Lakes District honors, averages 12.9 points and 7.4 assists.

ALL IN THE FAMILY — After helping Cuyahoga Heights to its first boys district basketball title since 1981, senior forward Jason Ryba credited his uncle, Kevin Domzalski, for the encouragement he gave him all season.

Domzalski was a standout on the Redskins' 1976 team that also advanced to regional play.

REUNION — Six members of the 1993 Gunning' Gals AAU team, which won the Lake Erie District 14-and-younger championship and advanced to national competition, will be reunited during this weekend's girls state tournament in St. John Arena in Columbus.

Chagrin Falls seniors Kelly Haase and Megan Anderson and junior Trish Kruse, and Magnificat seniors Brianne Kennelly, Sara Kitchen and Karen Hansen, were all former Gunning' Gals.

Haase, Anderson and Kruse will help lead the Tigers (25-1) against Miami East (23-2) tonight at 9 in a Division III semifinal. Kennelly, Hansen and Kitchen take the court to-

morrow night when the Blue Streaks (23-3) face Mason (24-1) in a Division I semifinal at 9.

SISTER ACT — Kennelly duplicated her sister's effort by being named the Division I Player of the Year in the Northeast Lakes District. Erin Kennelly, a former Plain Dealer player of the year and a standout at Syracuse University, captured the AP honor in 1989 when she led Holy Name to the big-school state semifinals.

THEY'RE BA-A-A-CK! — Of the 16 girls teams competing for the state's four division titles, Magnificat is the only returnee from last season. The Blue Streaks were Division I state semifinalists in 1996.

IRISH EYES WILL BE SMILING — Magnificat's basketball team and state champion gymnastics team will take part in Monday's St. Patrick's Day Parade. Rumor has it that Blue Streaks Athletic Director Therese Chambers Arth will lead the contingent.

HURRICANE WARNING — After winning three games in 1995 and one game last season, Brooklyn's boys varsity team finished 10-11 in 13 of the Hurricanes' 20 regular-season games, coach Mark Costantino started four sophomores.

CANNING HONORS — Barberton forward Keri Canning has been named the top senior player in the area by the Women's Tri-County Coaches Association, which will stage its all-star doubleheader at Kenmore High on Monday, starting at 6 p.m.

Canning will be one of 52 seniors divided onto four teams. She will be joined by teammates Jessica Jensen and Meghan Bennett on Team A, which will be coached by Canning's father, Tom, and Ravenna's John Davison.

Four members of Wadsworth's regional championship team — Jenny Martin, Kristin Hoover, Krista McCall and coach Todd Osborn — are members of Team B. The Whitmer brothers, Hudson's Tony and Tallmadge's Greg, will coach Team C, which includes Buchtel's Talesha Findley, the MVP of the Akron City Series.

They will play against Team D, coached by Bruce Reichenbach of Our Lady of the Elms and Manchester's Bob Eckert. That team includes Melissa Kury, April Mezick and Crystal Reeves, who led Coventry to the semifinals of the Division I district tournament.

ON THE AIR — WHIO-AM/640 will broadcast tomorrow night's Division I girls state semifinal game between Wadsworth and Pickerington at 6:40 and carry Saturday's state championship game at 8:10 p.m., if Wadsworth makes it that far.

EDDIE DWYER, TIM ROGERS

Martins mobilize

Wadsworth girls will have plenty of support in state semifinal tomorrow from star guard's plentiful, basketball-loving family

By TIM ROGERS

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

When the Wadsworth girls basketball team walks into St. John Arena tomorrow night, they might get the feeling they've walked in on the Martin family reunion.

In a small way, that'll be just what they've done.

Wadsworth will play mighty Pickerington in the Division I state semifinals at 7 p.m., and the Martin family — 30 and climbing at last count — will be there.

For sure, they will be there to watch the Lady Grizzlies, who will make the school's first appearance in the girls Final Four and the school's first appearance in the final four in any team sport since the boys shocked Canton McKinley in the regional finals in 1981.

They also will have an eye cast on one player in particular. Her name is Jenny Martin and she starts at guard. You can't miss her. She's the one with the blond ponytail and the smile as wide as I-76. She's also the owner of a 3-point shot that can be a killer and a knowledge of the game that's to die for.

Jenny Martin is the daughter of a coach and plays the game as such. Her father, John, started the girls program at Wadsworth and now coaches the boys. John Martin and his wife, Lynn, also are the parents of Stephanie, Eric and Luke. Stephanie and Eric, now students at Ohio State, had distinguished high school athletic careers under their father's tutelage. Luke, a member of this year's junior varsity, waits in the wings.

"Having the girls make it to Columbus is a great thrill for our family," said Martin, who has coached the boys for the last four years after nine years as the girls coach. "When you think of the athletic successes our family has had over the years, all the league and postseason championships that we've been fortunate enough to be a part of, this is the ultimate. We're living a dream at our house this week. I'm having a hard time coming up with enough tickets for the family."

That's because the Martin rooting section in Columbus won't be limited to Jenny's immediate family. It also will include aunts



BILL KENNEDY / PLAIN DEALER PHOTOGRAPHER

Jenny Martin is head coach of Wadsworth's boys basketball team, but all eyes will be on his daughter, Jenny Martin, tomorrow night in Wadsworth's state semifinal game.

and uncles and cousins.

"Let's see," said Martin, counting on his fingers. "There's five in our family, and I have three brothers and two sisters and most of them and their children are coming. Lynn's parents and sister are coming in from Kentucky, and her brother and his two children will be there. And my folks will be there too. We are going to have a riot."

Jenny, who also was a state qualifier as an individual in cross country in the fall, might have most of the fun though.

"I think this has been the most exciting week of my life," she said. "I haven't stopped smiling since Friday when we beat Wooster

and the phone at our house hasn't stopped ringing all week."

Jenny Martin is one of those kids whose smile can light up a gymnasium. So can her 3-point shot.

Ask her if she is the best 3-point shooter in school, and she laughs and says, "Heck, I'm not the best 3-point shooter in my family, let alone the school."

During the regular season Martin shot 36 percent on 3-point shots, easily leading Medina County with 41.

"Jenny Martin is a good shooter," said Pickerington coach Dave Butcher, whose team is 26-0 and ranked second in the nation by USA Today. "She's a very solid two guard. We'll have to know where she is."

While most consider Martin as an ideal off-guard, coach Todd Osborn said Martin brings more to the game than just a good shooting eye.

Osborn also tells this story: "Early in Jenny's junior year we would bring her off the bench if we needed some offense," Osborn said. "Then we realized that we were better defensively when she was in there. Jenny is a very underrated defensive player."

"When Jenny was a sophomore, I was convinced she would never play for us," he said. "I didn't like the way she practiced. I didn't think she had a very good work ethic. We would be explaining things and she would be off to the side shooting baskets. She would get into a scrimmage for a few minutes, and when I would take her out, she would go and shoot baskets again instead of watching what was going on. All the time I thought she was just goofing off."

Then I put her in a game against Copley and she did exactly what we wanted her to do on the floor and scored 16 points to boot. It wasn't until then that I realized that all the while she was shooting baskets, she was listening to us. She was working on her shot and listening to us at the same time. Here, I thought she was goofing off and all the while she was working twice as hard as anyone else."

That hard work has paid off with a trip to Columbus for Jenny Martin and the Grizzlies. And, there will be a bunch of Martins along for the ride.

Chagrin Falls' Phillips honored

FROM STAFF AND WIRE REPORTS

Frank Phillips, who has guided Chagrin Falls to a 25-1 record and its first state Final Four appearance since 1983, leads the list of area honorees on the 1996-97 Associated Press Girls Division III All-Ohio basketball team.

Phillips, who will lead the Tigers against Castown Miami East (23-2) in a state semifinal matchup tonight at 9 in St. John Arena in Columbus, shared coach-of-the-year honors with Utica's Tom Russell and Wauseon's Brad Myers. The trio has a combined record of 76-1.

Wauseon (25-0) faces Utica (26-0) in tonight's other semifinal.

Chosen for the first team were Hoban senior point guard Jackie Windon, who averaged 18.5 points a game during the regular season, and Columbia's Jamie Krivak, a 5-8 senior who averaged 23 points. Krivak was the Division III Player of the Year in the Northeast Lakes District.

Chagrin Falls senior Kelly Haase, who averages 15.7 points, was a second-team selection, and Hawken School's Jacquie Negrelli, a 5-6 junior who averaged 23.5 points, was named to the third team.

GIRLS BASKETBALL DIVISION III ALL-OHIO

COLUMBUS (AP) — The 1996-97 Associated Press Division III Girls All-Ohio high school basketball team, based on the recommendations of a state media panel (with school, league, district and regional coaches).

FIRST TEAM: Megan McCabe, Cincinnati Wyoming; 6-2, Senior, 15.0. Jamie Lewis, Oak Hill, 5-5, Sr., 22.8. Anna Babbs, Utica, 5-8, Sr., 17.5. Jessica Hinos, Barnesville, 5-8, Jr., 27.0. Katie Griggs, Wauseon, 5-11, Jr., 18.5. Jamie Zerbe, Lafayette Allen East, 5-8, Sr., 20.4. Jodi Windon, Hoban, 5-5, Jr., 18.5. Sue Porter, Cuyahoga Falls, 5-5, Jr., 16.9. Jamie Krivak, Columbia, 5-8, Sr., 23.0.

SECOND TEAM: Angie Berham, Castown Miami East, 5-8, Sr., 14.5. Kelly Haase, Chagrin Falls, 6-0, Sr., 15.7. Shelly Lehman, Marion Ely, 5-10, Sr., 17.5. Nicole O'Neil, Martins Ferry, 5-8, Sr., 15.1. Ashley Fank, Carey, 5-11, Jr., 19.8. Kelly Coyner, Beloit, 5-5, Sr., 24.0. Robin Thayer, North Lima South Range, 5-6, Jr., 23.0.

THIRD TEAM: Sharon Pillow, North Bend Taylor, 6-3, Jr., 22.4. Stacy Wright, Johnston Monroe, 6-0, Sr., 22.3. Shaw Davis, Ashland Creekview, 5-8, Sr., 18.6. Megan Kellogg, Bainbridge Point Valley, 5-11, Sr., 17.5. Molly Mahaffey, Bainbridge Point Valley, 5-8, Sr., 18.7. Jacqui Nagall, Hawken School, 5-6, Jr., 23.5. Amy Bundy, Mineral Ridge, 5-10, Sr., 14.6.

Players of the year: Megan McCabe, Cincinnati Wyoming; Jamie Lewis, Oak Hill.

Coaches of the year: Frank Phillips, Chagrin Falls; Tom Russell, Utica; Brad Myers, Wauseon.

AREA SPECIAL MENTION Kelly Roach, Garrettsville; Leslie Novak, Cardinal; Trish Kruse, Chagrin Falls.

AREA HONORABLE MENTION Sally Gaydon, Manchester; Katie Carson, Chagrin Falls; Charlene Maron, Harvey; Jessica Riser, Lodi, West.